

Study Finds India's Tiger Population Doubled in 12 Years

A recent study says India has doubled its tiger population in 12 years.

Researchers said the gain came from efforts to protect the big cats from hunters, and to protect against the loss of tiger habitat and prey, among other things.

The National Tiger Conservation Authority said the number of tigers grew from an estimated 1,706 in 2010 to around 3,682 in 2022. Those numbers mean India is home to about 75 percent of the total tiger population.

The research shows that a reduction in conflict between humans and wildlife also played a part in the population growth. The study credited efforts to improve economic conditions for communities near tiger habitats. The researchers said the growth in the tiger population also led to improvements in local economies through increased ecotourism.

The study appears in the publication *Science*. It said India's success demonstrates that wildlife protection can help both biodiversity and nearby communities.

"The common belief is that human densities preclude an increase in tiger populations," said Yadvendradev Jhala. Jhala is a scientist at Bengaluru-based Indian National Academy of Sciences and was the study's lead writer. "What the research shows is that it's not the human density, but the attitude of people, which matters more."

Wildlife conservationists and ecologists welcomed the study. But they said making the source data available to a larger group of scientists would aid tigers and other wildlife in India. The study was based on data collected by Indian government-supported organizations.

FILE - A Royal Bengal tiger drags a wild boar after killing it at the Ranthambhore National Park in Sawai Madhopur, Rajasthan, India, June 10, 2015. (AP Photo/Deepak Sharma, File)

Arjun Gopalaswamy is an ecologist who knows how to measure wildlife populations. He said that estimates from India's official tiger observation program have been undependable. He said some of the numbers in the study are much higher than past estimates of tiger populations from the same datasets. But he added that the study's findings seem to have corrected a data problem noted repeatedly by scientists since 2011 related to tiger population size and their range.

The study said tigers disappeared in some areas. These included habitats that were not near national parks or other protected areas, and areas of increased development, increased human use of forest resources and areas with armed conflict.

“Without community support and participation and community benefits, conservation is not possible in our country,” said Jhala.

That means local people need to see good results from their efforts to save tigers.

Tigers are spread across about 138,200 square kilometers of India. But just 25 percent of the area is rich in tiger prey and is protected. Another 45 percent of tiger habitat is shared with about 60 million people, the study said.

Jhala said strong wildlife protection legislation is the “backbone” of tiger conservation in India. “Habitat is not a constraint, it's the quality of the habitat which is a constraint,” he said.

Wildlife biologist Ravi Chellam, who did not take part in the study, praised the tiger conservation efforts as promising. But, he said, such efforts need to be extended to other wild animals to better care for the whole ecosystem in India.

Chellam said several kinds of Indian wildlife are “on the edge,” and need more attention.

I’m Caty Weaver.

The Associated Press reported this story. Caty Weaver adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

habitat - n. ถิ่นที่อยู่, แหล่งที่อยู่ตามธรรมชาติของพืชหรือสัตว์

prey - n.เหยื่อ, สัตว์ที่ถูกล่าเพื่อเป็นอาหาร

ecotourism - n. การท่องเที่ยวเชิงนิเวศ, การท่องเที่ยวเพื่อชมธรรมชาติและสัตว์ป่า

biodiversity - n. ความหลากหลายทางชีวภาพ, ความหลากหลายของสิ่งมีชีวิตในระบบนิเวศ

preclude - v. กีดกัน, ป้องกันไม่ให้เกิดขึ้น, ทำให้เป็นไปไม่ได้

attitude - n. ทศนคติ, ท่าที, ความคิดหรือความรู้สึกที่แสดงออกมา

conservationist - n. นักอนุรักษ์, ผู้ทำงานเพื่อรักษาสัตว์ พืช และทรัพยากรธรรมชาติ

range - n. ขอบเขต, พื้นที่ที่พืชหรือสัตว์อาศัยอยู่ตามธรรมชาติและสามารถพบได้

constraint - n. ข้อจำกัด, การถูกจำกัด

participation - n. การมีส่วนร่วม, การเข้าร่วม

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is the main finding of the recent study about India's tiger population?

- A. India's tiger population has decreased by half in 12 years.
- B. India's tiger population has doubled in 12 years.

- C. India's tiger population has remained stable for over a decade.
- D. India's tiger population has increased by 75% in the last year.

2. According to researchers, what was a primary reason for the increase in India's tiger population?

- A. An increase in the number of tiger hunters.
- B. Efforts to protect tigers from hunters and habitat loss.
- C. A significant decrease in the number of tiger prey.
- D. Expansion of urban areas into tiger habitats.

3. According to the National Tiger Conservation Authority, what percentage of the total global tiger population does India host?

- A. Approximately 25 percent.
- B. Roughly 50 percent.
- C. About 75 percent.
- D. Exactly 100 percent.

4. Besides direct protection efforts, what other factor did the research identify as contributing to tiger population growth?

- A. Increased conflict between humans and wildlife.
- B. A decline in ecotourism activities.
- C. A reduction in conflict between humans and wildlife.
- D. Fewer efforts to improve economic conditions for local communities.

5. How did the growth in the tiger population positively affect local economies?

- A. It led to a decrease in ecotourism.
- B. It caused a reduction in human-wildlife conflict.
- C. It resulted in improvements through increased ecotourism.
- D. It forced communities to move away from tiger habitats.

6. India's success in tiger conservation, as stated in the publication Science, demonstrates what broader principle?

- A. Wildlife protection only benefits biodiversity, not human communities.
- B. Wildlife protection exclusively leads to economic decline for nearby communities.
- C. Wildlife protection can help both biodiversity and nearby communities.
- D. Biodiversity is unrelated to the health of local communities.

7. What was Yadvendradev Jhala's main argument regarding factors affecting tiger populations?

- A. Human density is the sole determinant of tiger population size.
- B. The attitude of people matters more than human density.
- C. An increase in human populations always precludes tiger growth.
- D. Tiger populations are unaffected by human presence.

8. What specific recommendation did wildlife conservationists and ecologists make regarding the study?

- A. They suggested that the study should be kept confidential.
- B. They advised making the source data available to a larger group of scientists.
- C. They recommended that the study's findings be ignored.
- D. They questioned the study's overall validity.

9. What did ecologist Arjun Gopalaswamy acknowledge about the current study's findings despite some concerns?

- A. The study's numbers are consistently lower than past estimates.
- B. The study failed to address any prior data problems.
- C. The study's findings seem to have corrected a long-standing data problem related to tiger populations.
- D. India's official tiger observation program has always been highly dependable.

10. In which types of areas did the study observe the disappearance of tigers?

- A. Habitats exclusively within national parks and protected areas.
- B. Areas with decreased human use of forest resources.
- C. Habitats not near national parks, areas of increased development, and armed conflict zones.
- D. Regions with stable human populations and thriving ecotourism.

11. According to Yadvendradev Jhala, what is essential for conservation to be possible in India?

- A. Strict government regulations alone.
- B. High human density near wildlife habitats.
- C. Community support, participation, and benefits.
- D. Complete isolation of wildlife from human interaction.

12. What does Jhala's statement in Paragraph 12 imply local people need in order for conservation efforts to succeed?

- A. They need more scientific training.
- B. They must see positive outcomes from their efforts to save tigers.
- C. They should be encouraged to hunt tigers more sustainably.
- D. They need to relocate away from tiger habitats.

13. What proportion of India's tiger habitat is shared with approximately 60 million people?

- A. 25 percent.
- B. 138,200 square kilometers.
- C. 45 percent.
- D. 75 percent.

14. What did Jhala identify as the "backbone" of tiger conservation in India, and what did he clarify about habitat?

- A. Ecotourism is the backbone, and habitat size is the main constraint.
- B. Strong wildlife protection legislation is the backbone, and habitat quality is the constraint.
- C. Community participation is the backbone, and human density is the constraint.
- D. Increased hunting is the backbone, and prey availability is the constraint.

15. Wildlife biologist Ravi Chellam praised tiger conservation efforts but suggested what for a better ecosystem in India?

- A. Reducing the current efforts to save tigers.
- B. Focusing exclusively on tiger populations.
- C. Extending such efforts to other wild animals.
- D. Increasing human development in protected areas.